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Interaction and Performativity in Digital Art Exhibitions

Abstract

The interactive element of a museum or gallery visit has the potential to create a truly deep and enduring experience. The visitor is no longer seen as passive stroller but actively engaging participant whose interaction contributes to the artwork itself. Technologically mediated artworks are increasingly popular in contemporary art exhibitions. Despite being positive visiting experience interactivity can also cause feelings of self-consciousness or shyness that potentially distracts the visitor from the artwork. Digital technology is used in exhibitions to offers complex and often passively captured forms of interaction, e.g. through sensors that monitor movements or other embodied activities. This raises concerns about perceived privacy and accessibility to art as well as visitors perception of art. Sociological perspective offers a new way of seeing the interactive art exhibitions from the visitors' perspective. Drawing on research carried out in the UK, this paper aims to contribute to the resolution of the following tension: on the one hand a positive visiting experience through interaction, and on the other feelings self-conscious and shyness induced by performative dilemma.

Key Words: Interaction, Pervasive Technology, Cultural Institutions, Symbolic Interactionism

Sociologists interests towards art has focused on the socially organised settings in which art is produced (Becker 1982) and exhibited (MacDonald 2002) as well as experienced by the visitors (Heath & vom Lehn 2004:43). Contemporary museums and galleries have become increasingly concerned with promoting public engagement through the consumption of interactive installations, as opposed to the traditional housing of static curiosities and authentic pieces. Artists and designers are utilizing digital technology to create the interactive element in their artwork in order to create meaningful experiences to the visitors. Interactive art is discussed in the literature as 'computer art',

'new media art', 'digital art' and so on, and in other contexts interactive art is understood as non-technological hands-on artwork. In this paper the term 'interactive art' is used to describe computer-based artworks unless otherwise mentioned. Visitor-centered design has been seen as one of the ways to attract visitors to museums (McLean 1993). Museum staff, exhibition designers and curators are under pressure to create attractive exhibitions that encourage visitor participation and evoke emotional and behavioral responses. Thus the manufacturing of experiences has become a key issue in the design process, with digital technologies playing an increasing role in rendering artworks accessible to all. However, interactive art requires a level of exploratory participatory visitor engagement with new technologies that can leave individuals feeling shy and hindered from taking part.

Museums and galleries have traditionally been seen as locations of 'high' culture (Williams 1958), whose visual and textual contents and spatial arrangements signify sophistication. Bourdieu and Darbel's classic study of European museums (1969) notes that the certain visitor groups may feel that they lack the cultural capital (knowledge, skills and experience) needed to perceive and experience arts in 'correct ways'. Bourdieu suggests that the ‘correct’ perception of artworks is a matter of cultural competence, acquired through socialization and education. Contemporary museums are adopting ideas from the visitor-centered design (Falk&Dierking 1992), participatory museums (Simon 2010) and inclusive museums. These ideas are examples of cultural institutions' aims to increase accessibility to sectors of the public who might otherwise be excluded. Revisiting Bourdieu and Darbel in the context of interactive art, it can be said that the exhibition visit still requires cultural competence to interact with technologically mediated artwork. The visitor-focused approaches are resulting that the visitors are required to adopt the interchangeable roles as experience creator as well as the experiencer. The visit to the interactive exhibition is created for the *user* who utilizes the technology but also for the *visitor* whose interests are aimed to be accommodated. However, museums’ and galleries as public spaces are still strictly coded with social rules and norms which the visitors’ self-presentation is tied. Sociological analysis aims to understand how the transformations of cultural institutions are affectively changing the role of the visiting public. To participate successfully the visitor should be equipped with relevant cultural and social capital in order to feel competent to interact (Bourdieu & Darbel 1969). The expectation of competence and willingness to engage in technological as well as artistic interactive environment can create a performative dilemma amongst the visitors.

The changed element of engagement is particularly evident in interactive exhibitions and the visitor is expected to partake with the artwork. The visitor’s response to the exhibits forms a part of its

communicative power and creates the meaningful experiences for the visitor. The artworks and installations on display in exhibition areas are seen as incomplete without the agency of the visitor, whose active engagement brings the artwork 'alive'. The interactivity pressures the visitors to the new performative actions as they engage with such exhibits. Ironically, interactive artwork objectifies the visitor by forcing them to become part of the artwork, a spectacle to look at and a possession of the artist. The visitors' interaction becomes a performance that is observed by other passing visitors and staff which may leave them feeling hindered or evaluated. This could bring in the concerns about misunderstanding the intended meanings of the artwork and feelings of lacking the cultural competence. Digital technology transforms the norms as the visitor is present in the exhibition area through sensors and his or her performance could be tracked or even displayed with artworks. The positive museum experience arises from successful interaction with artwork and fellow visitors i.e. feelings of competence. Drawing from social theory of symbolic interactionism it can be said that the situationally emerging emotions are interconnected with increased performativity; instead of experiencing or perceiving arts the visitors are observing their own and the fellow visitors' performances. The performative turn in museum visit will change the way of how the visitors perceive and experiencing arts.

The theory of Symbolic Interactionism have been central to this work conceptualizing the social interaction in technologically equipped art environment as a social encounter whose meaning is negotiated between the actors (Denzin 1970, Silverman 1987). In particular Erwin Goffman's (1959) idea of presentation of self has been used to analyze the visitors' emotional responses to the public engagement with interactive art. Following SI analysis in social emotions it can be seen that they are emergent products of interaction and relative to the social context rather than a psychological trait or individual pathology (Scott 2006). Shyness and embarrassment can be defined as a situational state of dramaturgical stress (Freund 1998; cf. Goffman 1959), which arises from an actor's perceived relative incompetence at managing a social encounter and their anticipation of embarrassment resulting from the communication of an unwanted impression of oneself to others (Scott 2007a; cf. Schlenker & Leary 1982). This notion leads to the Goffman's (ibid) presentation of self in everyday life, where he sees interactions as forms of performances with audience, back-stage and front stage regions. Following Goffman's (see also Scott 2004) approach the feeling or fear of breaking the rule or norm and appear to others as incompetent visitor, is actually a reflection to the *competent other;* the actual or anticipated audience. The exhibition design is lacking to acknowledge the affects of presence of other people in exhibition area. In traditional museum or gallery settings the visitors' level or performativity is relatively low as he or she could just stroll around passively. The interactive exhibition the increased performativity can be seen as a trigger for

the feelings of relative incompetence.

The data for this research was collected in collaboration with Dr. Susie Scott and Dr. Tamsin Hinton-Smith, sociologists from the University of Sussex, as part of the WINES3-project called 'Supporting Shy Users in Pervasive Computing'. We examined two contrasting case studies; Fabrica, a small local contemporary art gallery in Brighton that hosted Tina Gonsalves' Chameleon, a multimedia artwork exhibition which utilizes facial recognition technology to provide emotional feedback to interactants i.e. visitors; and the V&A (Victoria and Albert Museum), a large traditional museum in London that hosted an exhibition called DeCode, which included a range of digital artworks by different artists that incorporate varying types of interactions from visitors; their body movements are reflected on a screen with multible colours, voice recognition creates illustrated shapes and figures on another screen. Both of the case studies were conducted over the duration of the exhibitions (2-3 months) and involved the triangulation of a range of data collection methods, including qualitative observational field notes, visitor tracking maps, self-completion visitor questionnaires, emotion maps, and visitor interviews conducted face-to-face, by email and by telephone. We also conducted 'walkaround interviews', a mobile methodology (Ross et al 2009) that involved the researcher accompanying a participant as they moved around the gallery and recording 'live' their responses to exhibits.

The research drawn upon this paper reveals that the common response to the public engagement with digital interactive technology in exhibition area is aloof and reserved. The visitors avoided or approached interactive exhibits with caution, and many reported feelings of uncertainty and fear of unexpected event, and therefore preferred to look aside while 'others' were interacting. This had both practical and emotional implications, as it prevented the visitors from interacting fully with the artworks by creating additional demands upon their own performance. The visitors also wanted to know in advanced what was going to happen in the interaction, and they requested more information from the staff members or reading carefully the information provided. Some of the visitors stated that they wanted to look at other people interacting before they 'give it a go', to avoid embarrassment of doing it 'wrong'. This scenario signifies people feeling incompetence in comparison to other visitors. As Scott (2007) states incompetent other refers to the audience around the social situation, and shyness is triggered by the frustrated sociability, the willingness and desire to participate but lacking the competence to do so. These examples also draws back to Bourdieu and Darbel and these notions are signifying that in public perception there is still an idea of 'correct way' to participate and interact with artwork. The technological incompetence was also reported as

being one of the factors that made the visitors feeling hindered to take part. Several respondents reported feelings of embarrassment, fear, shyness and anxiety which can be labeled as social emotions (see more: Hochschild 1983, Bendelow & Williams 1998,) or 'self-conscious emotions' (Tangney & Fischer 1995) that occur when people reflect upon their own behavior or status in social interaction.

This paper have indended to highlight the importance of recognising the effects of social intearction and performativity in exhibition design process. The interaction with individual and the artwork is a complex process with multible variables what can potentially distract the visitors' artistic experience. To summarise, active engagement in interactive exhibition requires high levels of performativity from the visitors and this can trigger or evoke social emotions which are connected to individual competence gained by his or her social capital and the interaction with surrounding audience. Exhibition design with interactive artworks requires profound understanding of the social setting, roles and interaction in public space. In accepting that the visitors experience is affected by fellow visitors as well as the technological devices allows the design process to manufacture experiences that are less of an shyness or embarrassment striken and more of enduring and exciting.

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